

BIHAR ORIGIN — MITHILA REGION

Makhana Curry

Fox Nuts in Rich Tomato-Yogurt Gravy
Bihar's Prized Aquatic Delicacy

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

LICENSE & COPYRIGHT NOTICE

Makhana Curry

Sold via: Gumroad
Publisher: DhanioDigital (dhaniodigital.gumroad.com)

PERSONAL USE LICENSE

This digital cookbook is licensed for personal, non-commercial use only.
You may print one (1) copy for your own kitchen use.

YOU MAY NOT:

- Share, resell, or redistribute this file in any form
- Upload to any website, cloud service, or file-sharing platform
- Remove or obscure any watermarks, copyright notices, or branding
- Use recipes for commercial food service without written permission

Violation of this license may result in legal action.

© 2024 DhanioDigital. All rights reserved.
Contact: support@dhaniodigital.com

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Makhana Curry

AUTHOR

Sweta Verma

PUBLISHER

DhanioDigital

COPYRIGHT

© 2026 Sweta Verma. All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced or distributed without written permission from the publisher.

DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Crop Grown in Water

Makhana, or fox nuts, are the puffed seeds of a prickly water lily cultivated in the ponds and wetlands of Bihar's Mithila region, particularly around Darbhanga, which produces the vast majority of the world's makhana supply — a distinction significant enough that Bihar's makhana earned a Geographical Indication (GI) tag, legally recognizing it as a product uniquely tied to the region. The harvesting process is genuinely demanding, with farmers wading into ponds to collect the seeds, which are then roasted and popped, similar in principle to popcorn, to produce the light, crunchy makhana found in kitchens and markets.

While makhana is often eaten simply as a roasted snack, makhana curry transforms it into a more substantial dish, simmered in a rich tomato-yogurt gravy that softens the fox nuts just enough to absorb the sauce while retaining a pleasant, slightly spongy bite. The dish carries genuine prestige in Bihari cuisine, often served at festive occasions and during religious fasting periods (vrat), when makhana's status as a light, easily digestible food makes it a favored choice.

In recent years, makhana has also gained considerable international attention as a health food, marketed abroad as a nutritious, low-calorie snack alternative — bringing global visibility to an ingredient that Bihari farmers and cooks have cultivated and treasured for generations, long before it appeared on Western wellness food lists.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Crop Grown in Water, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Cultivated primarily in Bihar's Mithila region, particularly Darbhanga, which holds a Geographical Indication (GI) tag recognizing its unique regional makhana production. Traditionally valued as a light, easily digestible food, making it a favored choice during religious fasting periods (vrat). Carries genuine prestige in Bihari cuisine, often served at festive occasions rather than as a purely everyday dish. Has gained significant international recognition in recent years as a health food, bringing global attention to a traditional Bihari agricultural product.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	25m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Kadai or wide pan
- Small blender, if making cashew paste
- Wooden spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Makhana curry is best enjoyed fresh, as the fox nuts can turn soggy with extended storage in the gravy. If needed, it keeps refrigerated for up to 2 days — reheat gently, though the texture will have softened further from its ideal state.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Makhana (fox nuts)	2 cups	60 g	2 katori
Ghee	3 tbsp	45 g	3 chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Onion, finely chopped	1 medium	100 g	1 medium
Ginger-garlic paste	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach
Tomato puree	1 cup	240 ml	1 katori
Plain yogurt, whisked	¼ cup	60 g	¼ katori
Kashmiri red chili powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Garam masala	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Cashews, ground to a paste — optional	2 tbsp	25 g	2 tbsp
Water	½ cup	120 ml	½ katori
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste
Fresh coriander, chopped, for garnish	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Makhana is increasingly available at health food stores and online outside India, often marketed as "fox nuts" or "lotus seeds" (a related but distinct term worth double-checking at purchase). If unavailable locally, this dish's technique also works well with paneer as a substitute, though the distinct spongy texture of makhana won't be replicated. The optional cashew paste adds extra richness but can be omitted for a lighter version.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Roasting the Makhana and Building the Base

01 ROAST THE MAKHANA

Heat 1 tablespoon of the ghee in a kadai and roast the makhana over medium heat for 5–6 minutes, stirring frequently, until they turn slightly crisp and lightly golden. Remove and set aside.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Roasting the Makhana and Building the Base, continued

Chef tip. roasting the makhana separately before adding to the gravy keeps them from turning uniformly soft, preserving some pleasant texture contrast.

02 SAUTÉ THE ONIONS

In the same kadai, add the remaining ghee and cumin seeds, letting them sizzle. Add the chopped onion and sauté until golden, about 7–8 minutes.

03 ADD AROMATICS AND TOMATO

Stir in the ginger-garlic paste, cooking until fragrant, then add the tomato puree, chili powder, and turmeric. Simmer for 8–10 minutes, until thickened and the oil separates slightly at the edges.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The tomato-onion base should be thick and glossy, with the raw tomato smell replaced by a deeper, rounder aroma, before you proceed to adding the yogurt.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Finishing the Curry

04 ADD YOGURT AND CASHEW PASTE

Reduce the heat to low, then stir in the whisked yogurt and cashew paste if using, stirring constantly for the first minute to prevent splitting.



05 ADD WATER AND SIMMER

Pour in the water and salt, and simmer for 5 minutes to let the gravy come together into a cohesive, medium-thick sauce.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Finishing the Curry, continued

06 ADD THE ROASTED MAKHANA

Gently fold in the roasted makhana and simmer for a final 3–5 minutes, just until they've absorbed some of the gravy while still retaining a slightly spongy bite. Finish with garam masala.

Texture indicator. the makhana should be tender but still have a pleasant, slightly springy texture — avoid over-simmering, which makes them uniformly soft and less interesting.

07 GARNISH AND SERVE

Finish with a scatter of fresh coriander just before serving.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Simmering the makhana too long in the gravy causes them to lose their pleasant texture entirely, turning uniformly soft. Add them toward the end and simmer only briefly.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with rice or roti, often prepared for festive occasions or during religious fasting periods.
- Valued as a light, easily digestible dish suitable for various dietary observances.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bowl with a rich, glossy gravy, garnished with fresh coriander and a few whole roasted makhana on top.

Family Style

- A special dish for festive family meals, given makhana's status as a prized regional ingredient.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Texture Right

- Roasting the makhana before adding to the gravy, rather than adding them raw, helps them hold their texture better during simmering.
- A brief final simmer, rather than a long one, is essential for keeping the makhana's characteristic slightly spongy bite.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The gravy base can be made a day ahead and refrigerated, with makhana roasted and added fresh just before serving for the best texture.
- This dish is best assembled close to serving time rather than fully prepared far in advance.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some cooks reserve a portion of plain roasted makhana to scatter on top just before serving, adding an extra crisp textural contrast against the softer makhana within the gravy.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

195 kcal	5 g	18 g	12 g	3 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Tree nuts. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Makhana Curry with Peas	some households add green peas for extra color and texture.
Vrat-Friendly Makhana Curry	a version made without onion and garlic, suitable for religious fasting observances.
Makhana Kheer	a completely different, sweet preparation using makhana in a milk-based dessert, popular during festivals.

Where can I buy makhana outside India?

Increasingly available at health food stores and online retailers, often marketed as "fox nuts" or "puffed lotus seeds" — check labeling carefully to confirm you're getting the correct product.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why did my makhana turn soggy?

Likely simmered too long in the gravy. Add roasted makhana toward the end of cooking and simmer only briefly to preserve their texture.

Is makhana curry suitable for fasting (vrat)?

A version without onion and garlic is commonly made specifically for fasting observances — check the variations section for this adjustment.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Makhana	fox nuts, the puffed seeds of a water lily cultivated in Bihar's Mithila region.
Vrat	a period of religious fasting during which certain foods, including makhana, are considered appropriate.
Mithila	a cultural and geographic region of Bihar, the primary makhana-growing area.
GI Tag	Geographical Indication, a legal recognition tying a product to its specific region of origin, held by Bihar's makhana.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Makhana Curry

10m	25m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	**Easy**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

DISH

Makhana	60 g
Ghee	45 g
Cumin seeds	4 g
Onion	100 g
Ginger-garlic paste	15 g
Tomato puree	240 ml
Plain yogurt	60 g
Kashmiri red chili powder	3 g
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Garam masala	1.5 g
Cashews	25 g
Water	120 ml
Salt	6 g
Fresh coriander	8 g

METHOD

01 **Roast the makhana.** Heat 1 tablespoon of the ghee in a kadai and roast the makhana over medium heat for 5–6 minutes, stirring frequently, until they turn slightly crisp and lightly golden.

02 **Sauté the onions.** In the same kadai, add the remaining ghee and cumin seeds, letting them sizzle.

03 **Add aromatics and tomato.** Stir in the ginger-garlic paste, cooking until fragrant, then add the tomato puree, chili powder, and turmeric.

04 **Add yogurt and cashew paste.** Reduce the heat to low, then stir in the whisked yogurt and cashew paste if using, stirring constantly for the first minute to prevent splitting.

05 **Add water and simmer.** Pour in the water and salt, and simmer for 5 minutes to let the gravy come together into a cohesive, medium-thick sauce.

06 **Add the roasted makhana.** Gently fold in the roasted makhana and simmer for a final 3–5 minutes, just until they've absorbed some of the gravy while still retaining a slightly spongy bite.

07 **Garnish and serve.** Finish with a scatter of fresh coriander just before serving.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Makhana	60 g	☐ Ghee	45 g
☐ Cumin seeds	4 g	☐ Onion	100 g
☐ Ginger-garlic paste	15 g	☐ Tomato puree	240 ml
☐ Plain yogurt	60 g	☐ Kashmiri red chili powder	3 g
☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g	☐ Garam masala	1.5 g
☐ Cashews	25 g	☐ Salt	6 g
☐ Fresh coriander	8 g		

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com